Scientists Find an Eyeless Snail in a Dark Cave

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Scientists have found a new kind of tiny snail living in a dark cave in China. It is the first **freshwater** cave snail ever found in that country.

The snail is called Erhaia dijiang. It lives in total darkness, so it has no eyes at all. Its shell is almost see-through, and its body has no color.

Its name comes from an old Chinese story about Di Jiang, a mountain god shown with no face. The snail really dislikes light. In the **lab**, the snails always hid under rocks when a light was on.

The cave is very high up, about 6,800 feet above **sea level**. The snails live in shallow water and eat tiny **algae** that grow on rocks.

But scientists are worried. They found only three living adults and no babies. They want people to study more caves in China and protect these rare snails quickly.

Word Treasure

freshwater -- Water that is not salty, like in rivers, lakes and caves.

lab -- A room where scientists do tests and experiments.

algae -- Tiny plant-like living things that grow in water.

sea level -- The height of the ocean, used to measure how high a place is.

Background you need

Animals that always live in dark caves often lose their eyes and color because they do not need them.

When very few animals of a kind are found, scientists work to protect them so they do not disappear.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists studying underground animals
WHAT: Found a new eyeless, see-through snail called Erhaia dijiang
WHERE: In a high cave in China
WHY: To learn about rare cave life and protect it

Why it matters

Finding and protecting rare animals helps keep nature full of amazing living things for kids in the future.

Test what you remember

1. Where was the new snail found?

- (A) On a mountain top in Peru
- (B) In a garden
- (C) In a dark cave in China
- (D) In the ocean

2. Why does the snail have no eyes?

- (A) Scientists hid them
- (B) It is a baby
- (C) It lives in total darkness
- (D) It lost them in a race

3. What does the snail's shell look like?

- (A) Covered in spikes
- (B) Bright red
- (C) Almost see-through
- (D) Square

4. What did the snails do when a light was on?

- (A) Grew bigger
- (B) Hid under rocks
- (C) Sang
- (D) Danced

5. What do the snails eat?

- (A) Pizza
- (B) Fish
- (C) Tiny algae on rocks
- (D) Leaves

6. How many living adult snails were found?

- (A) Three hundred
- (B) Thirty
- (C) None
- (D) Three

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. The scientists: Are worried about the snail and want people to protect it quickly.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):